

Cord & Stack Size Reference Card

Free from the Firewood Winter Calculator -- what a cord, face cord, and rick really look like

The five sizes you will hear a seller use

Full cord

128 cu ft

4 ft tall x 4 ft deep x 8 ft long, stacked tight
The only size defined by law in most US states.

Half cord

64 cu ft

4 ft x 4 ft x 4 ft
Fine, as long as the price is half of a full cord's.

Face cord / rick

~43 cu ft

4 ft x 8 ft, one row deep (about 16 in, one piece length)
About one-third of a full cord -- the most common way buyers get shorted.

Thrown (loose) cord

~180 cu ft loose

dumped, not stacked
Loose wood has more air gaps. It settles to well under a real stacked cord.

8-ft pickup bed

~65-70 cu ft

loaded level, not heaped over the rails
A half-ton truck cannot legally carry a full cord of oak -- that load weighs close to two tons.

How to measure a delivered load

Measure the stack's height, depth, and length in feet.

Multiply the three numbers together. That is the cubic feet.

Divide by 128. That is how many full cords you got.

Get it in writing: ask for cords on the receipt, not "truckloads" or "face cords."

The face-cord trap

A face cord has no fixed depth -- it depends on how the seller's saw cuts each piece.
Ask the piece length before you compare a price between two sellers.